net behind Casillas. It'd flown in. Nothing to do with the circumstances. I was celebrating what I'll remember as my best free-kick ever in a Manchester United shirt.

At 3–3 in the game, I was buzzing. I felt like I'd been plugged into something. Still two-down on aggregate but there was more in us, I was sure. But then, all of a sudden, Madrid players were coming up to me and having a chat, while this incredible match was crackling on around us. First, Guti ran alongside me and asked me if we could swap shirts at full-time. Then, Roberto Carlos was grinning at me again:

'Are you coming to play for us?'

Ten minutes left and it was Zidane's turn.

'David? Your shirt?'

I was chasing around, still trying to make things happen. Those players weren't trying to psyche me. They were just stone cold sure they could beat us all night long. Why not sort out the formalities now? Maybe they were right to be so relaxed. Maybe they did always have enough that, however close we got to them, they'd just find another gear. Five minutes from time, though, Ruud made a great run into the box. His shot came backoff the keeper and I stretched out at the far post and toed it over the line as me and Ivan Helguera fell down in a heap together. I could glimpse supporters' faces in the crowd behind the goal in the Stretford End. Not just celebrating, but their eyes widening:

'What's going on here?'

Because of their away goals—Ronaldo's goals—we still needed another two to advance. But there was enough time to get them. The Real coach, Vicente del Bosque, brought on an extra defender: for the first time in three hours, Real were going to try and hold on to what they had. I got one cross in that Ole, who'd played really well, couldn't get proper contact on. It was the kind of chance that, five minutes into a game, he'd have scored from. And then we got another free-kick, on the edge of their box. It was almost dead center and, this time, my shot went over the bar. There went my match ball.

We'd won the game, but lost on aggregate. I couldn't help it. Of course I was disappointed we were out of the Champions League. As we shook hands with the Real players, there was a moment or two of: if only. And then, elation washed over me. I felt more fulfilled by the 30 minutes of soccer I'd